Lesson 24: Introductions

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 4.4 Writing Introductory Paragraphs; and Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 2.4 Essay Introductions.

In this lesson

You study what an essay introduction does and how it is built: a hook, background information and a thesis statement, arranged from general to specific like a funnel. You analyse two model introductions about stereotypes and then write the introduction for the essay you planned in Lessons 22 and 23. A clear introduction tells a university reader at once what your essay argues and why it matters.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain the purposes of an introduction and name its three parts.
- Choose a hook strategy that suits an academic essay.
- Write background information that defines key terms and, in a summary/response essay, summarizes the source.
- Write a thesis that states a position and reasons instead of announcing the topic.
- Order an introduction from general to specific (the funnel technique).

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
introduction (introductory paragraph)	the first paragraph; it prepares the reader for the body of the essay	"The introduction of an essay is like a frame for the essay."
hook	the opening sentence(s): they introduce the topic and make readers want to read on	"Did you know that what others assume about you can affect how well you perform on a test?"
background information	the context for the thesis: key terms, sources, history, the debate	a short summary of the chapter "Stereotype Threat"
thesis statement	one sentence (usually) with your controlling idea: your position and reasons	"... make an understandable and compelling argument for the existence of stereotype threat"
funnel technique	moving from general statements to the specific thesis	general facts → narrower focus → thesis

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
anecdote	a short personal story	the story about the speech competition
proverb	a short traditional saying	"Until the lion learns to write, every story will glorify the hunter."
announcement	a sentence that only says what the essay will do	"In this essay, I will give three examples of ..."
voice and tone	the writer's attitude toward the subject	An introduction establishes your voice and tone.
cogent	clear, logical and convincing	"a clear, cogent thesis statement"
compelling	convincing and powerful	"a compelling argument"
stereotype threat	"a situation in which someone is stereotyped, is aware of the stereotype, and is taking part in an activity related to the stereotype"	the topic of the model introduction

Rules and explanations

What an introduction does

Hall and Wallace compare an introduction to a **storefront window**: in a small space it attracts readers to your subject and brings them inside your discussion, where you try to "make the sale" (make them accept your thesis). Winer and Wadell compare it to a **picture frame**: it prepares readers for the ideas in the body. An introduction:

1. establishes your voice and tone (your attitude toward the subject);
2. introduces the general topic and gives readers the information they need to understand your paper;
3. states the thesis that the body paragraphs will support.

First impressions last: a dull or disjointed introduction makes readers lose interest. However, the introduction does not have to be written first. Many writers write it last, when they are sure of their main points.

Three parts, from general to specific

Part	Its job	In the model introduction on stereotype threat
Hook	introduce the topic with a general statement and engage the reader	a question about what others assume about you
Background	define the topic, show why it matters, give context	a summary of the chapter "Stereotype Threat"
Thesis	state your controlling idea: what you will prove and why	"Overall, McRaney and her colleagues make an understandable and compelling argument ..."

This order is the **funnel technique** (general to specific): begin broadly, narrow the focus step by step, and end with the thesis. Move smoothly and logically from one sentence to the next.

Hook strategies

Strategy	Book example or note
General statement	"It is hard to admit that we may be affected by other people's stereotypes of us." (The book prints "peoples'", a mistake: the possessive of *people* is *people's*.)
Proverb	"According to an African proverb, 'Until the lion learns to write, every story will glorify the hunter.'"
Quotation	the words of the author Yaa Gyasi from her novel *Homegoing* (lesson material)
Question	"Did you know that ...?" The thesis should answer the question.
Story (anecdote)	the student who heard a classmate's comment before a presentation (lesson material)
Dictionary definition	define the key term of your essay
Background ("back story")	why you are writing on this topic
Striking fact or statistic	a surprising number or fact; it must be true and cited

You can also describe an event or pose a problem. In Hall and Wallace's words, a good introduction "engages people's emotions or logic, questions or explains the subject, or provides a striking image or quotation."

Background information

The background defines your topic and shows why it matters. You may introduce important sources, define key terms, give a brief history or explain a debate. In a **summary/response essay**, the background is a summary of the text: the authors, the title and type of source, the main points, phrases that show the ideas come from the source ("According to research reported by McRaney et al."), and citations.

The thesis statement

- It is your controlling idea: what you intend to prove, your position, and your reasons.
- It is generally one sentence (longer in a long essay).
- It presents an idea, not an announcement: avoid "In this essay, I will give three examples of ...".
- In U.S. academic writing it usually comes at the end of the introduction. It is the **roadmap** to your essay.

Balance and a mistake in the book

- Keep the introduction and the conclusion about the same length, and let them mirror each other.

- The second Key Takeaway in Hall and Wallace's section 4.4 ("An introduction should restate your thesis, review your main points, and emphasize the importance of the topic") describes a **conclusion**, not an introduction; it repeats their section on conclusions (Lesson 26). An introduction *states* the thesis; a conclusion *restates* it.

Psychology note: the model uses MLA paragraph citations such as (par. 1). Psychology uses APA style, with the author and year: (Steele & Aronson, 1995). In a psychology research report, the introduction reviews earlier studies and ends with the purpose or hypothesis of the study.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Formal Arabic prose often opens with very broad statements ("Since the beginning of time, people have ..."). In English, keep the hook short and reach your specific topic within two or three sentences. - Arabic has no capital letters, so check names and titles in your background: Kristy McRaney, *The Psychology of Gender*, "Stereotype Threat."

Practice

Exercise 1. True or false? Use both sections.

1. The funnel technique moves from specific ideas to a general thesis.
2. An introduction establishes the writer's voice and tone.
3. You must write the introduction before the body paragraphs.
4. In U.S. academic writing, the thesis usually comes at the end of the introduction.
5. "In this essay, I will give three examples of stereotypes" is a strong thesis.
6. If the hook asks a question, the thesis should answer it.
7. The introduction and the conclusion should be about the same length.
8. In a summary/response essay, the background includes a summary of the text.

Exercise 2. A complete introduction. Read the complete introduction on stereotype threat ("Let's put it all together") in the lesson material.

1. Which hook strategy does the writer use?
2. In the background, find (a) the authors, (b) the title and the type of source, (c) the definition of the key term, (d) four phrases that show the ideas come from the source, (e) how the writer shows where each idea is in the source.
3. The thesis gives three reasons why the argument is compelling. What are they?
4. Which word in the second sentence links the background to the hook?

Exercise 3. Find the parts. Read the sample introduction in "Identifying the parts of an introduction" (it begins "Have you ever realized ..."). Find the hook, the background and the thesis. Which hook strategy is used? Is the thesis an idea or an announcement?

Exercise 4. Write hooks. Write three new hooks for the introduction in Exercise 3: (a) a general statement, (b) a short story, (c) a definition.

Exercise 5. From announcement to thesis. Rewrite this announcement as a thesis with a position and reasons: "In this essay, I will give three examples of how stereotypes affect students."

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my thesis and outline from Lessons 22 and 23: [paste]. Suggest three possible hooks with different strategies, but do not write my introduction."
- "Ask me: 'Have you ever realized that your first impression about someone was wrong?' Discuss it with me, then help me turn my answer into a short anecdote hook."
- "Check my answers to Exercises 3 and 5 in the lesson."
- "Here is my introduction: [paste]. Does it move from general to specific? Is my thesis an idea or an announcement? Is the background enough for a reader who does not know the topic?"
- "Show me the opening paragraph of a chapter in OpenStax Psychology 2e. Ask me to find the hook, the background and the main idea."

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each slash (/).

1. Did you know / that what others assume about you / can affect how well you perform on a test?
2. According to an African proverb, / "Until the lion learns to write, / every story will glorify the hunter."
3. It is hard to admit / that we may be affected / by other people's stereotypes of us.
4. This is just one of the findings / reported by Kristy McRaney and her colleagues.
5. Overall, / McRaney and her colleagues make an understandable and compelling argument / for the existence of stereotype threat.
6. "Single stories" develop from making assumptions about others / based on hearsay or the media.

Writing task

Write the introduction for the essay you planned in Lessons 22 and 23 (thesis and outline). If you prefer a new topic, choose one and write a working thesis first: the "single story" and stereotypes (the book's topic), or a PSYC 110 topic such as how sleep affects memory, or how students cope with stress.

- Length: one paragraph of 120 to 200 words.
- Parts: a hook (choose one strategy), background information (define key terms; in a summary/response essay, summarize the source with the author, title, main points and citations), and your thesis as the last sentence.

Self-editing checklist:

- Does my hook introduce the topic and make a reader want to continue? Is any fact or statistic true and cited?
- Does the paragraph move from general to specific, without jumps?

- Does the background define the key terms and give the context a reader needs?
- Are my sources named, introduced with phrases such as "According to ...", and cited?
- Is my thesis the last sentence, and does it state a position and reasons (not "In this essay, I will ...")?
- Have I left detailed evidence for the body paragraphs?
- Are names and titles capitalized correctly?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Excelsior Online Writing Lab, "Introductions" (the source of the book's section on the purpose of an introduction; purpose and strategies): https://owl.excelsior.edu/writing-process/introductions-and-conclusions/introductions/

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. False: it moves from general to specific.
2. True.
3. False: many writers write the introduction last.
4. True.
5. False: it is an announcement, not an idea.
6. True.
7. True.
8. True.

Exercise 2

1. A question: "Did you know that what others assume about you can affect how well you perform on a test?"
2. (a) Kristy McRaney and her colleagues (McRaney et al.). (b) "Stereotype Threat," a chapter in the textbook *The Psychology of Gender*. (c) "a situation in which someone is stereotyped, is aware of the stereotype, and is taking part in an activity related to the stereotype." (d) Any four of: "reported by Kristy McRaney and her colleagues"; "In this chapter, McRaney and her colleagues discuss"; "According to research reported by McRaney et al."; "McRaney and her colleagues also look at research"; "their article acknowledges and responds to." (e) Paragraph numbers in parentheses: (par. 1), (par. 5), (par. 8), (McRaney et al. par 9).
3. The information is engaging, it seems balanced, and it helped the writer make sense of her own experiences.
4. "This" ("This is just one of the findings ..."): it points back to the idea in the question.

Exercise 3

- Hook: the opening questions, "Have you ever realized that your first impression about someone was wrong? It is common to have this experience, but it can be useful to understand more about why you thought this. Were your first impressions based on someone's race, gender, general appearance, age, etc.?" (Some readers count only the first question as the hook; the next two sentences develop it.) Strategy: a question.
- Background: from "Chimamanda Adichie describes a similar experience in her TED talk, 'The Danger of a Single Story.'" to "... knowing only a single story is a danger and it leads to creating stereotypes." It summarizes the talk.
- Thesis: the last sentence, "'Single stories' develop from making assumptions about others based on hearsay or the media, so the way to combat them is to increase opportunities for genuine interaction between people from different backgrounds." It is an idea (a cause and a solution), not an announcement.

Exercise 4 (example answers)

- (a) Everyone forms first impressions of other people, often before they have spoken a word.
- (b) On my first day at university, a classmate asked me whether I had ever seen snow. She assumed that everyone from my country lived in the desert; she knew only one story about my country.
- (c) A stereotype is a fixed, simplified idea about a whole group of people. (If you quote a dictionary, cite it.)

Exercise 5 (example answer) Stereotypes harm students because they can lower test performance, make students feel unwelcome in their classes, and limit the careers that students choose.

My notes